

SIKANDRA KURDI

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Professional Experience

Assistant Professor, American University in Cairo, Public Policy and Administration. 2026-present.
Egypt Country Program Leader, International Food Policy Research Institute. 2023-2026.
Research Fellow, International Food Policy Research Institute. 2021-2026.
Associate Research Fellow, International Food Policy Research Institute. 2017-2021.
Postdoctoral Scholar, PODER Fellowship. Paris School of Economics. 2015-2016.

Education

University of California, Berkeley. Ph.D. in Agricultural and Resource Economics, 2015.
Kazan Federal University, Russia. Specialist in Mathematical Methods in Economics, 2009.
Swarthmore College, B.A. in Economics with High Honors, 2006.

Journal Publications

- Mahmoud, M., and Kurdi, S. (forthcoming). "Heterogeneity in Food Aid Impacts: Foundations for Improved Targeting." *Journal of Development Economics*
- Bertelli, O., and Kurdi, S. 2026. "Inter-Group Cooperation and Conflict: Experimental Evidence From Yemen." *Oxford Bulletin of Economics and Statistics* 88(1). <https://doi.org/10.1111/obes.70039>
- El-Enbaby, H., Gilligan, D., Karachiwalla, N., Kassim, Y., and Kurdi, S. 2025. "Cash Transfers, Gender Norms, and Women's Control over Decision-Making in Egypt." *Economic Development and Cultural Change* 73(4), 1721–1760. <https://doi.org/10.1086/732909>
- Bliznashka, L., Elsabbagh, D., Kurdi, S., Ecker, O., and Gelli, A. 2024. "School Feeding for Improving Child Nutrition in Conflict-affected Settings: Feasibility and Cost Efficiency of Alternative Models in Yemen." *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences* 1540, 251–264. <https://doi.org/10.1111/nyas.15222>
- Breisinger, C., Kassim, Y., Kurdi, S., Randriamamonjy, J., and Thurlow, J. 2024. "From Food Subsidies to Cash Transfers: Assessing Economy-Wide Benefits and Trade-Offs in Egypt." *Journal of African Economies* 33(2), 109–129. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jae/ejad006>
- Abay, K., Yonzan, N., Kurdi, S., and Tafere, K. 2023. "Revisiting Poverty Trends and the Role of Social Protection Systems in Africa during the COVID-19 Pandemic." *Journal of African Economies* 32(Supplement_2), ii44–ii68. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jae/ejac041>
- Abay, K., Breisinger, C., Glauber, J., Kurdi, S., Laborde, D., and Siddig, K. 2023. "The Russia-Ukraine war: Implications for global and regional food security and potential policy responses." *Global Food Security* 36, 100675. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.gfs.2023.100675>
- Brune, L., Karlan, D., Kurdi, S., and Udry, C. 2022. "Social Protection Amidst Social Upheaval: Examining the Impact of a Multi-Faceted Program for Ultra-Poor Households in Yemen." *Journal of Development Economics* 155, 102780. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jdeveco.2021.102780>
- Kurdi, S. 2021. "The Nutritional Benefits of Cash Transfers in Humanitarian Crises: Evidence from Yemen." *World Development* 148, 105664. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.worlddev.2021.105664>

Figuerola, J.L., and Kurdi, S. 2020. "Ex-post Adjustment for Measurement Error in Stunting Calculations: An Illustration from Egypt." *Public Health Nutrition* 23(5). <https://doi.org/10.1017/S1368980019003100>

Kurdi, S., Figuerola, J.L. and Ibrahim, H., 2020. "Nutritional Training in a Humanitarian Context: Evidence from a Cluster Randomized Trial." *Maternal & Child Nutrition* 16(3).
<https://doi.org/10.1111/mcn.12973>

Working Papers

Abay, K., Abdelfattah, L., Elkaramany, M., Elsabbagh, D., and Kurdi, S. "Nutrition-Sensitive Food Distribution Amidst Inflationary Shock: Evidence from a Randomized Intervention in Egypt." *Revise and resubmit at Economic Development and Cultural Change*
Discussion paper version published as : IFPRI Discussion Paper 2218. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.137031>

Hashad, R., Jovanovic, N., Karchiwalla, N., and Kurdi, S. "Inflation and diets among poor mothers in Egypt." *Revise and resubmit at Food Security*
Discussion paper version published as: IFPRI Discussion Paper 2394. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/179553>

Allen IV, J., Gilligan, D.O., Kurdi, S., and Yassa, B. "Would you rather: Voluntary take-up of a poverty graduation program among cash transfer recipients."
Discussion paper version published as: MENA Working Paper 44. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/158340>

Karachiwalla, N., Gilligan, D.O., and Kurdi, S. 2024. "Don't spend it all in one place: The medium-term effects of a national cash transfer program on household well-being."
Discussion paper version published as: MENA Working Paper 45. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/168421>

Steinhubel-Rasheed, L., Keenan, M., and S. Kurdi. "Conflict, Market Access, and Smallholder Livelihoods in Yemen."

Book Chapters

Kurdi, S., Hassan, G., Jovanovic, N., and Steinhuebel-Rasheed, L. 2025. Regional developments: Middle East and North Africa. In *Global food policy report 2025: Food policy: Lessons and priorities for a changing world*, eds. Johan Swinnen and Christopher Barrett. Part Six: Regional Developments and Priorities, Chapter 24, Pp. 555-567. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/174358>

Kurdi, S. 2025. Lessons Learned on Food Security in the Yemen Crisis. In *Food and Humanitarian Crises: Science and Policies for Prevention and Mitigation* eds. Joachim von Braun, Bettina Iseli, Maximo Torero and Peter Turkson. Vatican City: Pontifical Academy of Sciences.
<https://www.doi.org/10.65398/PGDW4081>

Becquey, E., Benin, S., Marivoet, W., Gelli, A., Abay, K.A., et al. 2024. Regional developments. In *Global food policy report 2024: Food systems for healthy diets and nutrition*. Chapter 9, Pp. 82-119. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/141893>

Abay, K., Karachiwalla, N., Kurdi, S., and Salama, Y. 2023. Food price shocks and diets among poor households in Egypt. In *The Russia-Ukraine Conflict and Global Food Security*, eds. Joseph Glauber and David Laborde. Section Four: Country Impacts and Responses: Middle East and North Africa, Chapter 25, Pp. 129-134. https://doi.org/10.2499/9780896294394_25

- Kurdi, S., Ecker, O., Glauber, J., and Laborde, D. 2023. Addressing the food crisis in Yemen: The private sector's key role amid local conflict and global market disruptions from the Russia-Ukraine war. In *Russia-Ukraine Conflict and Global Food Security*, eds. Joseph Glauber and David Laborde. Section Four: Country Impacts and Responses: Middle East and North Africa, Chapter 28, Pp. 145-149. https://doi.org/10.2499/9780896294394_28
- Kurdi, S., Breisinger, C., Glauber, J., and Laborde, D. 2023. The Russian invasion of Ukraine threatens to further exacerbate the food insecurity emergency in Yemen. In *The Russia-Ukraine Conflict and Global Food Security*, eds. Joseph Glauber and David Laborde. Section Four: Country Impacts and Responses: Middle East and North Africa, Chapter 27, Pp. 140-144. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/139709>
- Kurdi, S., and Ruckstuhl, S. "Crisis Resilience: Anticipatory Action and Humanitarian Response." *2023 Global Food Policy Report*. https://doi.org/10.2499/9780896294417_03
- Elsabbagh, D., Kurdi, S., and Wiebelt, M. 2022. Impact of falling remittances amid COVID-19 on Yemen's war-torn economy. In *COVID-19 and global food security: Two years later*, eds. John McDermott and Johan Swinnen. Part One: Food Security & Poverty, Chapter 7, pp. 51-53. <https://ebrary.ifpri.org/digital/collection/p15738coll2/id/135017>
- Kurdi, S., Breisinger, C., ElDidi, H., El-Enbaby, H., Gilligan, D., and Karachiwalla, N. 2018. "Targeting Social Safety Nets Using Proxy Means Tests: Evidence from Egypt's Takaful and Karama Program," *ReSAKSS Annual Trends and Outlook Report 2018*. International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://www.resakss.org/node/6689>

Policy Notes

- Allen IV, J., Gilligan, D.O., Kurdi, S., Shokry, N., and Yassa, B. 2025. Gendered work norms in Egypt: Evidence on preferences and social perceptions. IFPRI Project Note. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/178587>
- Jovanovic, N., Darwish, M., Kurdi, S., and Yamauchi, F. 2025. Solar powered drip irrigation: Lessons learned from an impact evaluation in Yemen. MENA Policy Note. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/179369>
- Shokry, N., Jovanovic, N., Kurdi, S., Hamdy, A., and Elkaramany, M. 2025. Addressing the double burden of malnutrition in Egypt: Report on a stakeholder workshop on key challenges, policy solutions, and research opportunities. MENA Policy Note 27. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/176182>
- Shokry, N., Yassa, B., and Kurdi, S. 2024. Challenges for private sector job matching in rural Egypt: Results from a survey of Forsa employers. MENA Regional Program Policy Note 25. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute. <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/159533>
- Ecker, O., ElAzzouzi, A., Kurdi, S., and Qasem, A. 2023. Unlocking the power of partnership to address Yemen's food crisis and strengthen food system resilience. IFPRI Issue Brief November 2023. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/9780896294592>
- Raouf, M., Kurdi, S., Cicowiez, M., Lofgren, H., Yassa, B., Kamaly, A., and Helmy, G. 2023. Egypt's Haya Karima Initiative: An assessment of its rural and economywide impacts. MENA Policy Note 23. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI) <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.137015>.

- Kurdi, S., Mahmoud, M., Abay, K., and Breisinger, C. 2020. Too much of a good thing? Evidence that fertilizer subsidies lead to overapplication in Egypt. MENA RP Working Paper 27. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.133652>.
- El-Enbaby, H., Elsabbagh, D., Gilligan, D., Karachiwalla, N., Koch, B., and Kurdi, S. 2023. Egypt's Takaful Cash Transfer Program: Impacts and Recommendations from the Second Round Evaluation. IFPRI Policy Brief, April 2023. <https://doi.org/10.2499/9780896294387>
- Elsabbagh, D., Kurdi, S., and Wiebelt, M. 2021. Impact of COVID-19 on the Yemeni economy: How the drop in remittances affected economic sectors, food systems, and households. MENA RP Project Note 15. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.134258>.
- Kurdi, S., Breisinger, C., Ghorpade, Y., Ibrahim, H., and Al-Ahmadi, A. 2019. "Responding to Conflict: Does 'Cash Plus' Work for Preventing Malnutrition? New Evidence from an Impact Evaluation of Yemen's Cash for Nutrition Program" IFPRI Policy Brief. <https://doi.org/10.2499/9780896293601>
- Breisinger, C., ElDidi, H., El-Enbaby, H., Gilligan, D., Karachiwalla, N., Kassim, Y., Kurdi, S., Jilani, A., and Thai, G. 2018. "Impact Evaluation of Egypt's Cash Transfer Program 'Takaful and Karama' Summary of Findings and Recommendations." IFPRI Policy Brief. <https://doi.org/10.2499/9780896295964>
- Kassim, Y., Kurdi, S., Mahmoud, M., and Breisinger, C. An Agricultural Policy Review of Egypt: First Steps Towards a New Strategy. 2018. MENA RP Working Paper 11. Washington, DC and Cairo, Egypt: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/145766>

Evaluation Reports

- Allen IV, J., Gilligan, D.O., Kurdi, S., Shokry, N., and Yassa, B. 2023. Impact evaluation report of Egypt's Forsa Graduation Program. MENA RP Working Paper 43. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.137034>
- Gilligan, D., Kurdi, S., Tabe-Ojong, M., and Yassa, B. 2023. Impact evaluation report: Egypt's Forsa graduation program. MENA RP Working Paper 43. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.137034>.
- El-Enbaby, H., Elsabbagh, D., Gilligan, D., Karachiwalla, N., Koch, B., and Kurdi, S. 2022. Impact evaluation report: Egypt's Takaful Cash Transfer Program: Second round report. MENA RP Working Paper 40. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.136395>
- Gilligan, D., Kurdi, S., Tabe-Ojong, M., and Yassa, B. 2022. Forsa pilot evaluation baseline survey results. MENA RP Policy Note 22. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.136467>
- El Shabrawy, A., Gilligan, D. O., Kurdi, S., Palloni, G., and Yassa, B. 2022. Forsa pilot program and evaluation plan. MENA Policy Note 24. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.135878>.
- Abdelaziz, F., Abay, K., El-Enbaby, H., Breisinger, C., and Kurdi, S. 2021. Impact of COVID-19 on Egypt's dairy and artichoke value-chains: Qualitative findings from rapid value chain assessments. MENA RP Working Paper 33. Washington, DC: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://doi.org/10.2499/p15738coll2.134390>.
- Bertelli, O., Kurdi, S., Al-Maweri, M., and Al Bass, T. 2019. Impacts on trust and social capital of a youth employment program in Yemen: Evaluation of the rural and urban advocates working for development

intervention for the Social Fund for Development. MENA RP Working Paper 24. Washington, DC; Cairo, Egypt: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/147228>

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Breisinger, C., Gilligan, D., Karachiwalla, N., Kurdi, S., El-Enbaby, H., Jilani, A., and Thai, G. 2018. Impact Evaluation for the Takaful and Karama Cash Transfer Program: Quantitative Report. MENA RP Working Paper 14. Washington, D.C.: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/147204>

ElDidi, H., El-Enbaby, H., Kassim, Y., Kurdi, S., Petesch, P., Moataz, Y., and Yassin-Goessinger, K. 2018. Impact Evaluation of Egypt's Takaful Cash Transfer Program: Qualitative Report. MENA RP Working Paper 15. Washington, D.C.: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/147205>

Breisinger, C., El-Enbaby, H., ElDidi, H., Gilligan, D., Jilani, A., Karachiwalla, N., Kassim, Y., Kurdi, S., Petesch, P., and Thai, G. 2018. Impact Evaluation of Egypt's Takaful Cash Transfer Program: Synthesis Report. MENA RP Working Paper 16. Washington, D.C.: International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). <https://hdl.handle.net/10568/147206>

Christian, S., Egel, D., de Janvry, A., and Sadoulet, E. 2013. Evaluation of the Labor Intensive Works Program. http://sfd.sfd-yemen.org/uploads/issues/LIWP_Impact%20Evaluation_5_27%283%29-20130527-133541.pdf (as Sikandra Christian)

Christian, S., Egel, D., de Janvry, A., and Sadoulet, E. 2014. Evaluation of the Rainfed Agriculture Program for Yemen Social Fund for Development. <http://sfd.sfd-yemen.org/uploads/issues/RALPeval-20140923-151253.pdf> (as Sikandra Christian)

Referee Service (alphabetical)

American Journal of Clinical Nutrition, Food Security, Food Policy, Journal of Development Economics, World Development, World Bank Economic Review

Languages

English (Native), French (Upper Intermediate), Russian (Upper Intermediate), Arabic (Lower Intermediate)